GETTING STARTED

Preparing for a medical appointment

Edited 14 October 2026

Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

How can you prepare for a visit?

Preparing for a medical appointment helps you discuss what matters most. Write down your main concern and a few questions about symptoms, medicines, or daily activities. If you have symptoms that suggest an emergency, seek help immediately rather than waiting for the appointment. [1,3]

Describe changes clearly

For a symptom that can wait for a routine discussion, note when it began, how often it happens, and what you are doing when it appears. Explain whether it changes your sleep or daily activities. You do not need medical language. A concrete description, such as feeling more breathless during a usual walk, may be more useful than saying only that you feel different.

Bring the right information

Ask the clinic what records are needed. A current medicine list, allergy information, relevant test results, and discharge documents may be helpful. Keep them together so you can find them quickly. If another clinic recently changed your treatment, mention that change. Do not send sensitive records to an unconfirmed email address simply because someone requests them in a message.

Ask what an instruction means

If a clinician recommends a test or treatment, ask its purpose and what happens next. You can ask about likely benefits, possible risks, alternatives, and costs. If a word is unfamiliar, request a simpler explanation. A diagram or written example may help. Asking for clarification is part of taking an active role in your care. [1,2]

Say what makes a plan difficult

Tell the team if transport, money, work, or caregiving duties make an instruction hard to follow. Explain the problem before the visit ends. A plan may need further discussion to become workable. If you have concerns about side effects or another treatment, say so rather than quietly stopping it. Be specific about what worries you and what information would help you decide.

Check your understanding

Repeat the agreed next steps in your own words. Confirm medicine changes, test preparation, activity advice, and follow-up dates. Ask which symptoms need a call and how to contact the right person. You can request written instructions. If you want a companion to take notes, ask whether they may join. Get permission before recording any part of the conversation. [1,4]

Review the plan at home

At home, update your medicine list and calendar. Keep the instructions where you can find them. Contact the clinic if anything is unclear or conflicting, and keep unanswered questions for your next discussion.

References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Preparing for medical visits. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/cardiac-rehab/communicating-with-professionals/preparing-for-medical-visits

2. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Working with your healthcare professional. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/consumer-healthcare/doctor-appointments-questions-to-ask-your-doctor

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Talking with your doctor. https://medlineplus.gov/talkingwithyourdoctor.html

4. Agency for Healthcare Research and Quality. (n.d.). Talk with your doctor. https://www.ahrq.gov/questions/resources/diagnosis/step3.html

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Ask about the program and appointment arrangements.
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